Language problem

Can Valid

March 2026

1 The Language Problem

Certain statements are elevated to extreme importance. We build mathematics, science, and whole worldviews on things like "$1+1=2$" or "gravity is real." Yet to a Chinese man who does not know English, or to an alien with no access to our symbols, such statements are indistinguishable from gibberish. They sound, in principle, no different from "jib jub jib pup pop."

This gives rise to the language problem: how can one justify treating a statement as a bearer of truth, or as a legitimate tool of analysis, when considered objectively it is just a pattern of marks or sounds, no more visibly significant than nonsense? Why should one string be held onto tightly while another is discarded, if both are, at first glance, only noise?

The language problem begins with a humiliation: the statements we treat as most profound do not wear their profundity on their face. To an outsider, "$1+1=2$" may be no more distinguished than "plip plup plop." If so, by what right do we cling to certain strings of language as if they grasp the world, while dismissing others as meaningless noise?

More formally, statements such as "$1+1=2$" or "gravity is real" are often treated as paradigms of truth or understanding. Yet, considered merely as inscriptions or utterances, they possess no obvious mark of epistemic privilege. To a speaker outside the relevant interpretive scheme, they may be indistinguishable from nonsense. The language problem is the difficulty of explaining how any such statement acquires the right to function as a bearer of truth, rather than remaining merely a structured noise.

2 Perfection as a Provisional Solution

One such procedure is what I call *perfection*. The term is potentially misleading if taken to mean idealisation in the usual scientific sense. Perfection does not mean that one replaces an object by an objectively ideal version of itself. Rather, perfection is a controlled act of maximal concession.

Suppose two speakers are engaged in a discussion, but the discussion is obstructed by a disputed dependency. One speaker interrupts the main line of analysis by demanding clarification of a side-question whose answer is not yet

fixed. The obstruction may be legitimate, but if every such dependency must be settled before inquiry can continue, discussion may become impossible. Perfection is the operation by which one party grants the other local authority over the disputed dependency, not forever, but sufficiently for the present argument to proceed.

The basic form of the move is this: if the other speaker insists that some unresolved parameter matters, one replies by granting that parameter whatever value the other speaker would ultimately endorse under sufficiently extended clarification. In this sense the object under discussion becomes "perfect" relative to the interlocutor's own standard. The perfection lies not in the object itself, but in the concessive act. One has made the strongest local concession available.

Consider a simple example. Newton wishes to discuss how an apple responds to gravity. Plato interrupts: what colour is the apple? At first sight the question threatens to derail the analysis. Newton replies that the apple is the "perfect" colour. This does not mean that there exists some objectively perfect colour for apples. It means: let the apple be whatever colour you, as the present authority on this sub-question, would finally accept as appropriate. If red is your standard, then red it is. If a more elaborate account is required, then let the apple satisfy that account. The purpose of the move is to suspend the dependency without pretending to have solved it in any final sense.

Perfection therefore functions as a pact. It says: for the purpose of continuing inquiry, I concede this branch of authority to you. The move only works if both parties remain oriented toward truth, or at least toward some eventual convergence. If the interlocutor has no stable standard, or no intention of allowing the discussion to terminate, perfection loses its force. Its validity therefore depends on a background assumption that the disputed dependency admits of some answer, and that the speakers are not merely performing indefinite obstruction.

Under these conditions, perfection offers a partial way through the language problem. It does not solve the problem globally. It does not establish once and for all how symbols acquire meaning, nor does it eliminate the possibility of semantic drift. What it does provide is a local mechanism for continuing inquiry in the presence of unresolved linguistic dependence. It allows a statement to function before every component of its surrounding language has been fully settled.

This is why perfection is philosophically interesting. When a speaker says that an object is "perfect" in the relevant sense, the utterance is not primarily a descriptive report. Its significance lies in what it *does*. It closes a dependency by concession, transfers local authority, and alters the inferential state of the conversation. In that sense its meaning exceeds its definition. The statement becomes effective not because it names a mysterious property, but because it performs a disciplined conversational operation.

Perfection should therefore be understood as a provisional semantic tool. It is not a substitute for clarification, and it is not a final theory of meaning. It is a method for preserving the possibility of analysis when language itself threatens to prevent inquiry from beginning.